Mian Zhang

billmianz2@gmail.com
mianzhang.github.io

Education

The University of Texas at Dallas — 2024–Spring 2027 (expected)
Ph.D. in Computer Science advised by Zhiyu Zoey Chen — *Dallas, TX*

Soochow University — 2020–2023
M.S. in Computer Science advised by Wenliang Chen — *Suzhou, China*
- Outstanding Graduate

Research Interests

Reinforcement Learning · RL Env · LLM/VLM Agents · Reliability · Efficiency

Research Experience

Scale AI — May. 2026–Aug. 2026
Research Intern — *San Francisco, CA*
Hosts: Manasi Sharma, Ying Liu, Daniel Yue Zhang
Developed Spine-Branch Coordination [1] for multi-agent computer use, increasing success rates by 6.0–16.5 percentage points and reducing per-task cost by 34–70%.

Zoom GenAI — May. 2025–Aug. 2025
Research Intern — *Seattle, WA*
Hosts: Kaiqiang Song, Zheng Chen
Developed LogicIF [2] for complex instruction following, combining verifiable data synthesis with RL to evaluate and improve logic-following accuracy by 10.7 percentage points.

Tencent AI Lab — May. 2024–Aug. 2024
Research Intern — *Seattle, WA*
Hosts: : Linfeng Song, Haitao Mi, Dong Yu
Research on preference learning.

The University of Texas at Dallas — Aug. 2024–present
Research Assistant — *Dallas, TX*
Advisor: Zhiyu Zoey Chen
Research on efficient agentic search, including Search Wisely [5] and HiPRAG [3]; improved accuracy by 5.1 points across seven QA benchmarks while reducing search calls by 29%.

Tencent — 2022
Research Intern — *Shenzhen, China*
Mentor: : Lifeng Jin
Research on dialogue understanding, inconsistency, and safety [9].

Papers (Selected)

The full publication list is at Google Scholar. * denotes equal contribution.

[1] **Spine-Branch Coordination for Multi-agent Computer Use** Preprint
Mian Zhang, Manasi Sharma, Sheng Zhang, Minlai Yang, Kejian Shi, Ying Liu, Zhiyu Zoey Chen, Daniel Yue Zhang

[2] **LogicIF: Towards Complex Logic Instruction Following** COLM 2026
Mian Zhang, Shujian Liu, Sixun Dong, Ming Yin, Yebowen Hu, Xun Wang, Steven Ma, Song Wang, Sathish Reddy Indurthi, Haoyun Deng, Zhiyu Zoey Chen, Kaiqiang Song

[3] **HiPRAG: Hierarchical Process Rewards for Efficient Agentic Retrieval Augmented Generation** ICLR 2026
Peilin Wu, **Mian Zhang**, Kun Wan, Wentian Zhao, Kaiyu He, Xinya Du, Zhiyu Chen

[4] **Mitigating Exploration Bias in RL for Multi-Instruction Following** EMNLP 2026
Mian Zhang, Yueqin Yin, Kaiyu He, Peilin Wu, Xinlu Zhang, Mingyuan Zhou, Zhiyu Zoey Chen

[5] **Search Wisely: Mitigating Sub-optimal Agentic Searches By Reducing Uncertainty** EMNLP 2025
Mian Zhang*, Peilin Wu*, Xinlu Zhang, Xinya Du, Zhiyu Zoey Chen

[6] **MMTok: Multimodal Coverage Maximization for Efficient Inference of VLMs** ICLR 2026
Sixun Dong, Juhua Hu, **Mian Zhang**, Ming Yin, Yanjie Fu, Qi Qian

[7] **Preference Learning Unlocks LLMs' Psycho-Counseling Skills** ACL 2026
Mian Zhang, Shaun M. Eack, Zhiyu Zoey Chen

[8] **CBT-Bench: Evaluating Large Language Models on Assisting Cognitive Behavior Therapy** NAACL 2025
Mian Zhang, Xianjun Yang, Xinlu Zhang, Travis Labrum, Jamie C. Chiu, Shaun M. Eack, Fei Fang, William Yang Wang, Zhiyu Zoey Chen

[9] **SafeConv: Explaining and Correcting Conversational Unsafe Behavior** ACL 2023 Oral
Mian Zhang, Lifeng Jin, Linfeng Song, Haitao Mi, Wenliang Chen, Dong Yu.

Selected Awards

Tinker Research Grant from Thinking Machines	2025
Researcher Access Program from OpenAI	2025
Outstanding Graduate Award at Soochow University	2023
First-class Scholarship at Soochow University	2020–2021
Principal's Award	2019
Mathematical Contest in Modeling National First Prize (top 1%)	2018